MCP

Title:
The Princess and the P

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THE PRINCESS AND THE P
By Steve DuBois

CAST OF CHARACTERS

ACTRESS 1:
MYNDA, PRINCESS OF LEXICO. Spoiled, but clever, and her heart is in the right place.

THE LETTER P. A mischievous consonant.

MAN-AT-ARMS. A particularly frustrated servant to the King.

MISTRESS OF LAWS. A servant to the King.

MINISTER OF AGRICULTURE. A servant to the King.

KING'S PHYSICIAN. A servant to the King.

ACTRESS 2:
CAEDMON, KING OF LEXICO. Elderly, kindly, and somewhat befuddled.

PRISICILLA. Chancellor to the King, and occasional provider of narrative exposition.

WITCH. A cunning woman and mistress of the magic of language.

AUTHOR'S NOTES

Scene breaks are marked with a #.

The witch's spell, the specific manner in which the missing Ps are verbalized, and other such production elements are left open to interpretation by the performers.

#

[1]MYNDA: Oh, father! I'm so uncomfortable! I tossed and turned and didn't sleep a wink all night!

[2]CAEDMON: What, again? *[sighs]* For what reason, my angel?

[1]MYNDA: It's the P, father! I can't sleep because of the P?

[2]CAEDMON: *[Nodding]* A rubber sheet, then. I shall instruct your chambermaids to…

[1]MYNDA: No, not that! The *letter* P! P is the source of all of your kingdom's misfortunes, father! Is it not true that the words we speak shape the reality in which we live?

[2]CAEDMON: In some respects. Discourse has power. The way in which we talk about people and things influences the way we interact with them. A lord who refers to his serfs as "dogs" will come to see them as less than human. A knight who calls his squire "boy" will raise up a less mighty warrior than one who calls that squire by name. And it is true that, here in the Kingdom of Lexico, words have even more power than they do elsewhere.

[1]MYNDA: And what element is common to all of the crises that beset your loyal subjects, father?

[2]CAEDMON: I suppose…money?

[1]MYNDA: No, father. Think harder.

[2]CAEDMON: Alcohol?

[1]MYNDA: No.

[2]CAEDMON: Millennials?

[1]MYNDA: *[Sighs, pulls out a scroll, hands it to the king]* I made a list. Behold, father. The source of all our troubles.

[2]CAEDMON: *[Reading]* Pestilence…poverty…prostitution…patriarchy?

[1]MYNDA: Oh, yes, father! I am so tired of the world being run by old while men who set arbitrary rules!

[Caedmon pauses and blinks a bit, then goes on reading.]

[2]CAEDMON: Plague…pneumonia…pets in restaurants. Hmmm. I perceive your point.

[1]MYNDA: It is the Ps, father! The Ps oppress us! Use the power granted to you as king! Instruct the royal wizards of Lexico to unleash their word-smithing energy to police our

language! Let every P be stricken and removed, that our people may prosper in the paucity of their plotting! May a purge become your urge!

[2]CAEDMON: Er…alas, beloved. I dare not.

[1]MYNDA: But father!

[2]CAEDMON: But me no buts, my sweet. This sort of thing has been attempted before. Even applied sparingly, word-magic is dangerous. It rends the fabric of reality itself. A change of such magnitude as you suggest…there is no forseeing the risks. No, my dumpling. I dare not.

[1]MYNDA: But…but FATHER!

[2]CAEDMON: I dislike these buts, and I cannot lie. The old white man has spoken, daughter. In time, you will come to see the wisdom of restraint. In the meantime, return to your bedroom beside the royal gardens. You will rule this kingdom one day, but not tonight.

[Mynda scowls and stomps away]

[2]CAEDMON: Now, that's trouble. But I suppose it can wait until morning. *[He squirms in discomfort]*. Ah…prostate. Another oppressive P word. It seems a purge may be necessary after all. To the royal chamber pot…

[Intro here]

[2]PRISCILLA: I, Lady Priscilla, had served as the King's chancellor for many years, and I knew that he was correct to predict trouble. For all seventeen years of her life, Princess Mynda had been spoken to with deference, and the words had shaped her. She was a haughty girl, perhaps a touch spoiled, with a will like a rod of castle-forged steel. But she was also shaped by the compassion and courtesy she had been shown. And as she thought upon the plight of her future subjects—of their pain, their panic, their peanut allergies, of their every peril and peccadillo, her heart swelled with pity. So that very night, she mounted her pony and rode forth, into the woods, to consult with the word-witch…

[1]MYNDA: I have come for your help, old crone.

[2]WITCH: What would you have of me, princess?

[1]MYNDA: *[Gasps]* You know who I am?

[2]WITCH: Nothing is hidden from the gaze of a cunning woman. The way you sit side-saddle on your pony bespeaks years of training. Your posture, regal and erect—the bent back of a peasant could never straighten so. Also, there's also that diamond-studded tiara you're wearing. The subtle clues pile up. *[She grins wickedly]* Care for an apple?

[Mynda shakes her head and dismounts]

[2]WITCH: Ah, well, worth a try. *[She clears her throat.]* Know, princess, that I am bound by an ancient formula: FOR MAGIC OR FOR SAGE ADVICE, ALL WHO COME HERE MUST YEILD THE PRICE. Yes, I am bound to follow every letter. The magic of language comes dear indeed, and in exchange, you must give up something dear to you. What would you have of me?

[1]MYNDA: The Ps, madam! I would have you round up every P in Lexico. Gather them together, and do with them I know not what. But rid us of them!

[2]WITCH: Ah, yes. A difficult letter, the P. One must mind them, as well as the Qs. An understandable concern. But this is no small task you ask of me. FOR MAGIC, OR FOR SAGE ADVICE, ALL WHO COME HERE MUST YEILD THE PRICE. The price here will be quite high.

[1]MYNDA: How high?

[2]WITCH: A kidney, I think.

[1]MYNDA: A *kidney*?

[2]WITCH: I get very few visitors out here. One grows tired of lentils and forest roots. A bit of protein in my diet will do me good.

[1]MYNDA: Oh…very well.

[2]WITCH: Excellent! Right though here, Princess, in my cottage…Yes, just past the Room of Unspeakable Objects in Jars…mind the flying monkeys…ah! Here it is! My loom…

[The Witch weaves a spell upon her loom. At the end of the spell, THE LETTER P emerges, stretches, looks around, giggles gleefully, and runs away.]

[2]WITCH: And…done! When the sun rises in the morning, the change will be achieved! The payment, please.

[The Witch holds out her hand. Mynda frowns.]

[1]MYNDA: Oh, bother. I just had them redecorated! But anything for my people…

[She reluctantly removes her left kidney and places it in the witch's hand.]

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[2]PRISCILLA: Mynda strode out into the night, where her steed returned her to the palace, and

to her bedroom by the royal gardens. The next morning, the sun shone in through her window. Had it all been a dream?

[*Mynda yawns and stretches.]*

[1]MYNDA: *ersimmon. *[She starts in surprise]* *achyderm. *[She smiles widely]* *eter *i*er *icked a *eck of *ickled *e**ers. It worked! Wait until I tell father!

[She goes racing out into the gardens, then as she sees them, her face crashes in dismay.]

[1]MYNDA: What…my flowers! They've…they've been vandalized! To the council chamber! Father! Father! FATHER!!!

[*She arrives in the council chamber and screams. Lady Priscilla stands in front of her, decapitated, but perfectly calm and addressing the court.]*

[1]MYNDA: Oh my God…Lady *riscilla...she's been deca*itated! But, it seems, none the worse for it…

[2]PRISCILLA: *[Headless, addressing the King]*: It is as I feared, your highness. Re*orts are flooding in from across the land as we s*eak, and the situation is identical throughout Lexico. Two in every ten citizens have vanished overnight, and everyone who's left seems to have a s*eech im*endiment. As best we can tell, the removal of a letter of our al*habet has wrought changes u*on the reality which that al*abet codifies. Wherever the letter has gone missing, reality has shifted accordingly. Hence: the immediate loss of two tenths of the kingdom's *o*ulation, including an eighth of the *easants, who do all the actual work.

[1]MYNDA: Lady *riscilla…my…my flowers…

[2]PRISCILLA: The flowers of your garden, your highness? I assume the daffodils and violets are unaltered?

[1]MYNDA: Yes. But the *etunias and the *eonies. They're…

[2]PRISICILLA: Missing their buds. Reduced to stems. Wherever the letter a**eared at the beginning of a word, the to* of the object in question has gone missing. In those cases, and in all others, the object in question has been shortened in *ro*ortion to the length of its name. I sym*athize with the loss of your flowers, highness, but believe me… *[she gestures to her missing head]* …others have it worse.

[A man-at-arms emerges, glances down at his crotch, then stares angrily at Mynda]

[1]MAN-AT-ARMS: Indeed.

[2]PRISCILLA: Yes. And the consequences don't sto* there.

[1]MISTRESS OF LAWS: Crime is ram*ant throughout the ca*ital! The *olice force finds itself shorthanded!

[2]PRISCILLA: And it gets worse.

[1]MINISTER OF AGRICULURE: The harvest! A full fifth of the cro*s have disa**eared from the fields! We will surely starve come winter!

[2]PRISICILLA: Some realities have been abbreviated by the absence of the letter. Others have been altered. For when the absence of a letter transforms one word into another, the world transforms with it…

[1]MINISTER OF AGRICULTURE: Our fruit orchards are ruined! Half of the trees are full of ale, and half are full of ears! Now half of our workers are too horrified to work, and half are too drunk!

[2]PRISCILLA: Was this what you wanted, *rincess?

[1]KING'S PHYSICIAN: Our doctors cannot administer *ills to their *atients! The very medicine itself makes them ill.

[2]PRISCILLA: A most sickening state of affairs.

[1]MARSHALL: The narrow mountain *ass that connected our kingdom to Slibola has been transformed into a giant *air of buttocks!

[2]PRISCILLA: It occurs to me, your highness, that had you been with child at the time this occurred, you would now be *regnant*…which is to say, a ruling queen. Was that your intention? Was this an attem*t at a cou*?

[1]MYNDA: I would never do that to father! I just wanted to hel* the citizens of Lexico…

[2]PRISICILLA: And so you have. They are in hell. What have you done, *rincess? And what will you do to make things right again?

[Mynda ponders the situation. And slowly, she comes to a conclusion.]

[1]MYNDA: I can…I can fix this. I'll need…I'll need some su**lies from the kitchens. And a wand, from one of our word-wizards.

[2]CAEDMON: A wand? You are royal! You are untrained in the ways of magic!

[1]MYNDA: I won't need to be. Trust me, everyone. I have a *lan.

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[Mynda, behind the wheel of an automobile, revs the engine, then hits the breaks. The Witch observes her arrival. All around her cottage, newly-enslaved Ps are hard at work, thatching the roof, mowing the lawn, whitewashing the fence, and so forth.]

[2]WITCH: Back so soon, *rincess? And regally mounted on a…1976 Buick, I see. Whatever became of your *ony?

[1]MYNDA: Headless, as you well know. Fortunately, the fish in my father's ornamental *ond were all transformed into cars. Madam, I have come once again to bargain, and to liberate these consonants from their confinement. What have you done to them?

[2]WITCH: I think not, my dialytic damsel. You cannot offer me your other kidney and ho*e to survive. Besides, I have come to enjoy the service of these letters. Roof re*air, cooking meals, yardwork…they have *roven most useful!

[1]MYNDA: Monstrous! Look at them, sweating in the hot sun, dragging their sad little tails behind them! Come now! Remember the creed that governs you! Let us strike a deal!

[2]WITCH: Go home. I have mastered the magic of words, and I find yours tedious.

[1]MYNDA: Very well. I came to buy, but if you will not bargain with me, I shall liberate these letters by force! *[She draws a wand.]*

[2]WITCH: You fool of a girl! You cannot be serious! I have dueled the mightiest masters of linguistic magic! Satyrs, demons, and lawyers have fallen before me by the score! You cannot ho*e to best me.

[1]MYNDA: *[Pointing her wand]* En garde, madam!

[2]WITCH: Oh, very well. *[She draws her own wand.]* Are you sure you want this, girl?

[1]MYNDA: I renew my offer to buy.

[2]WITCH: Not likely. On three, then. One, two, and…ALACAFRAGILASICARAZAM!!!

[There is a short pause. Then, The Letter P emerges and, delighted, runs squealing away from the witch.]

[2]WITCH: Still alive? Impossible. But…wait…how can I say that word? *[Noticing the fleeing Ps]* Come back! Come back, you! What have you done, girl?

[1]MYNDA: Why, I offered to buy. And you responded with…

[2]WITCH: With a spell! A fatal spell! A word of sure and certain power...A sp…

[1]MYNDA: Not a spell, under the circumstances. Rather: a *sell*. And it was a pleasure doing business with you. *[She puts her wand away and turns to go.]*

[2]WITCH: GRRRAAGGGH. Oh. But highness, aren't you forgetting something? We made an exchange. A legally and magically binding contract. You owe me a kidney…and it is a debt you cannot pay without forfeiting your life. I may be, suddenly, an unlettered woman, but still, I shall dine tonight. And not just on a single kidney, oh no indeed…

[1]MYNDA: We did have a deal. And I shall pay you all that I owe.

[She reaches into her car, and withdraws a small package, which she tosses to the witch, who opens it.]

[2]WITCH: This isn't a kidney! This is rice! What, do I look *vegan* to you?

[1]MYNDA: *[Climbing back into the car.]* I believe you once told me that you operated under an ancient formula, which you must follow to the letter. And our deal was made under unique phonetic conditions, madam. Speak, if you wish, the words of your ancient creed. The words you spoke when we made our deal. And tell me what I owe.

[As the witch speaks, Mynda starts up the engine.]

[2]WITCH: For magic, or for sage advice, all who come here must yield the…must yield the… *[She realizes her mistake, and raises her wand.]* GRRRRRRRAAAAAAAAAGH!!!

[Mynda accelerates away.]

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[2]PRISCILLA: In truth, things in Lexico never did get completely back to normal. A few Ps decided that they enjoyed the heady taste of freedom, and rather than returning to their assigned roles, they took to the open road, taking up life as hitchhikers, highwaymen, troubardors, and rogues. And every now and then, a blank space would turn up where a P was needed, and a suffering typesetter would shake his or her fist in the direction of the capital, cursing what had become known as Mynda's Mistake. But the worst of the crisis had passed. The missing citizens returned, as did the crops and missing appendages. Mynda's father and I were quick to forgive her. And when she finally came into her kingdom, she ruled with compassion and wisdom—recognizing the power of words, but rarely seeking to police them. Instead, she dealt directly with the problems they described.

[As she speaks, The Letter P emerges from behind her, and attempts to sneak away.]

[2]PRISICILLA: Neither the problems nor the problematic language were ever completely eradicated. Nevertheless, all involved lived more or less ha**ily…

[She notices the missing letter, spots the P, and shakes a finger at it. It sighs and returns to her side, rolling its eyes.]

[2]PRISCILLA: happily ever after.

[She nods with satisfaction. Priscilla and the P share a fist-bump.]